UNIT 1: BEGINNING YOUR JOURNEY, CAREER READINESS ORIENTATION

TOPIC 5: COMMUNICATION SKILLS

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand the importance of both verbal and nonverbal communication
- Understand that there are different communication styles
- Understand the importance of communication skills at work

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Identify their own communication style
- Show effective communication through role plays
- Identify important aspects of verbal and nonverbal communication

Topic ACTIVITIES:

I. Welcome to the Day

Opening Question:

- If you could have a conversation with someone famous (dead or alive), who would it be? What would you want to talk to them about?

Opening Quote:

- "The single biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place."
  ~ *George Bernard Shaw* (playwright)
- "Speak when you are angry — and you'll make the best speech you'll ever regret."
  ~ *Dr. Laurence J.Peter* (educator)
- "To effectively communicate, we must realize that we are all different in the way we perceive the world and use this understanding as a guide to our communication with others."
  ~ *Anthony Robbins* (self-help author and motivational speaker)
- "We have two ears and one mouth so that we can listen twice as much as we speak."
  ~ *Epictetus* (philosopher)
- "Communication works for those who work at it."
  ~ *John Powell* (film score composer)
- "The way we communicate with others and with ourselves ultimately determines the quality of our lives"
  ~ *Anthony Robinson* (author, speaker)
- "Kind words can be short and easy to speak, but their echoes are truly endless."
  ~ *Mother Teresa* (missionary, minister to the poor, sick, orphaned, and dying)

Real-World Application Check-in:

- Ask participants to share observations and thoughts.

II. Verbal Communication Activities

1. **Drawing Bugs** (directions and picture included)

2. **Taboo** (board game)

   "***Taboo*** is a word guessing party game published by Hasbro in 1989. The object of the game is for a player to have his/her partner(s) guess the word on his/her card without using the word itself or five additional words listed on the card." http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Taboo_(game) retrieved April 7, 2010

   Rules for Clues

   - No form or part of ANY word printed on the card may be given as a clue. Examples: If the Guess word is PAYMENT, "pay" cannot be given as a clue. If DRINK is a Taboo word, "drunk" cannot be given as a clue. If SPACESHIP is the Guess word, you can't use "space" or "ship" as a clue.
   - No gestures may be made. Examples: You can't form your hand in the shape of a gun to clue for "shoot"; or point to your nose to clue for "beak."
   - No sound effects or noises may be made, such as explosions or engine noises. However, feel free to break out into song.
   - You cannot say the Guess word "sounds like" or "rhymes with" another word.?
   - No initials or abbreviations can be given if the words they represent are included on the card. Examples: MD cannot be used if MEDICAL or DOCTOR is the Guess word or a Taboo word. TV cannot be used if TELEVISION is the Guess word or a Taboo word.

   From http://www.centralconnector.com/GAMES/taboo.html retrieved April 7, 2010

   You could buy the game or create examples connected to work.

   Example:

   Guess Word: Interview

   Taboo Words: Job, Questions, Answers, Candidate, Conversation

III. Verbal Communication Discussion

- What are the different aspects of Verbal Communication?
  - Word Choice
  - Integrity/trust (What value do your words have?)
  - Clarity (Do your words clearly relay your message?)
- How important is verbal communication?
  - At work?
  - In interviews?
  - In e-mails and text messages? How often is there confusion with messages dependent solely on words?
  - Emoticons were created to help clarify e-mail messages
  - What role does verbal communication have in responding to supervisors, co-workers, customers?
- What are the different roles of Verbal Communication?
  - Explain things
  - Give directions
  - Clarify something

IV. Nonverbal Communication Activities

1. Line Up

Supplies: No supplies needed

Directions:

- Instruct participants that they will need to line up in a particular way, as quickly as they can, WITHOUT TALKING (or writing or texting or using words at all).
- Round one: Shoe size (Identify where the person with the smallest shoe size should stand, and where the person with the largest shoe size should stand — with everyone else in between).
- Round two: Birthday — month and day. (Again, identify where person whose birthday is closest to Jan 1st should stand and where person whose birthday is closest to Dec 31st should stand).
- Round three: Alphabetical by last name (Identify where 'A' should go and where 'Z' should go).

Possible Discussion Questions:

1. How did you communicate? (eye contact, gestures, pointing, hands/fingers, nodding, etc.)
2. Was everyone communicating the same way? If not, how did you understand each other?
3. How easy/difficult was it to communicate without words? Explain what was difficult and what was easy.
4. Did anyone take the lead to make sure you were in the right order? Would that have helped?
5. What was frustrating about this activity?

2. Charades

Supplies: words/phrases written on index cards (or pieces of paper)

Directions:

You can divide the group into two teams and do a charades relay race, or you can have participants act out the words/phrases for everyone to guess for fun. No talking allowed.

For the team relay race, you will need two sets of the words/phrases and at least two people to facilitate the race.

- Divide the group into two teams.
- Each team has a facilitator that holds the team's cards.
- The group decides what order they will play the game (who will go first, second, third, etc).
- Once the order for each team has been established, the teams race to act out all of the cards one at a time and have their team guess it correctly.
- The first person acts out the first card and once it is correctly guessed by the team, the second person goes to the front, grabs the best card and acts it out. Play continues until one team has correctly guessed all of the cards.

Discuss the challenges of relaying a message without using words.

Was it easier or more difficult than the 'bug activity'? Why?

Is non-verbal or verbal communication more important? What evidence supports your position?

How has technology helped communication? How has it hurt communication?

3. Picture/Video Clips without sound

Supplies: pictures or video clips

Directions:

Show the pictures and/or video clips (without sound) to participants and have them guess what is going on.

- How do you think the person feels?
- What might the person/people be saying?
- What is being communicated?
- How easy is it to identify feelings and/or understand messages without words?
- Is it easier or harder than trying to identify feelings, messages without nonverbal cues?

V. Nonverbal Communication Discussion

- What are the different aspects of Nonverbal Communication?
  - Facial expressions
  - Body language, posture
  - Gestures
  - Eye contact
  - Touch
  - Space
  - Voice (not what you say, how you say it)
  - Other things?
- How important is Nonverbal Communication? How important is it at work?
  - "One study at UCLA indicated that up to 93 percent of communication effectiveness is determined by nonverbal cues. Another study indicated that the impact of a performance was determined 7 percent by the words used, 38 percent by voice quality, and 55 percent by the nonverbal communication." http://humanresources.about.com/od/interpersonalcommunicatio1/a/nonverbal_com.htm
- Roles of Nonverbal Communication

  Nonverbal communication cues can play five roles:
  - **Repetition:** they can repeat the message the person is making verbally.
  - **Contradiction:** they can contradict a message the individual is trying to convey.
  - **Substitution:** they can substitute for a verbal message. For example, a person's eyes can often convey a far more vivid message than words and often do.
  - **Complementing:** they may add to or complement a verbal message. A boss who pats a person on the back in addition to giving praise can increase the impact of the message.
  - **Accenting:** they may accent or underline a verbal message. Pounding the table, for example, can underline a message.

  Source: The Importance of Effective Communication, *Edward G. Wertheim, Ph.D.*

  http://www.helpguide.org/mental/eq6_nonverbal_communication.htm

VI. Determine your Communication Style

Have participants complete one (or both) of the following assessments to learn more about their own communication style and the communication styles of other people in the group. Discuss what they learn and whether or not they agree with the assessment. How will understanding your communication style help you communicate more effectively? How will understanding other communication styles help you communicate more effectively?

- Director, Socializer, Thinker, Relator http://occonline.occ.cccd.edu/online/klee/CommunicationsStyleInventory.pdf
- Aggressive, Passive, Assertive http://www.au.af.mil/au/awc/awcgate/sba/comm_style.htm OR http://trainingpd.suite101.com/article.cfm/communication_styles

VII. Practicing Effective Communication at Work

Role Plays: Divide participants into groups of 2 or 3. Give each group one or two topics and instruct them to create skits that show effective communication practices. For fun, you can also ask them to create skits using ineffective communication practices.

Possible topics:

- Receiving directions
- Handling feedback
- Communicating a problem to your supervisor
- Handling a customer complaint
- E-mail miscommunication
- Training a new employee
- Answering a tough question in a job interview
- Meeting your co-workers on your first day of work

VIII. Read and Discuss *Ten Questions to Improve Your Communication Skills*

Real-World Application: Pay attention to how you communicate with different people in your life and what you can do to improve your communication effectiveness.

Drawing Bugs

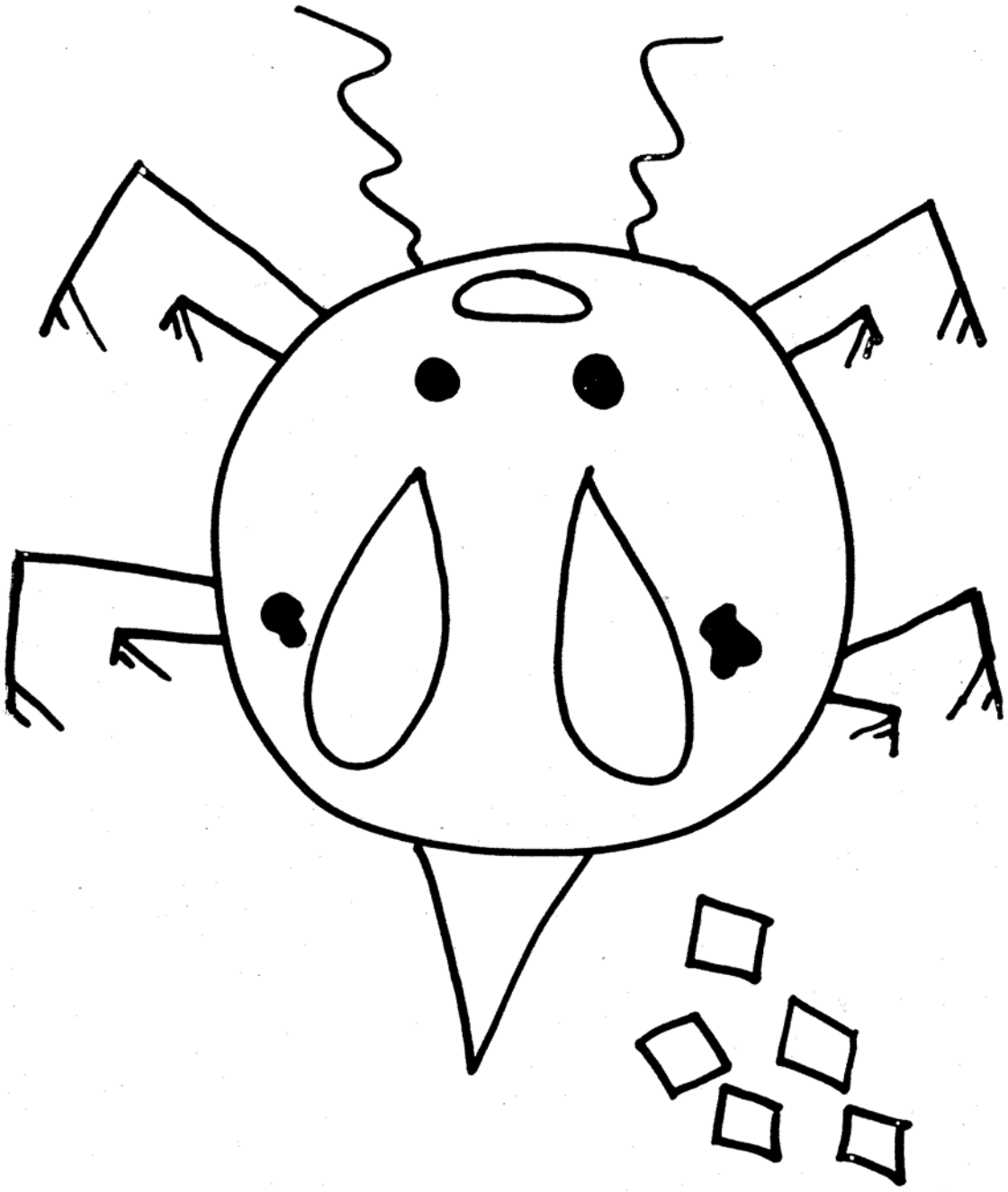
Materials needed: Paper and pencil for each participant.

- I am going to describe a drawing I have made of a bug. (Bug drawing attached). Without seeing the drawing, you are to draw the bug that I describe. You may not ask questions or talk to each other.
- Describe the bug.
    1. The bug is round.
    2. The bug has eight legs, grouped in pairs with four legs on the left and four legs on the right. In the pairs, one leg is longer than the other.
    3. The bug has two eyes on top of the body.
    4. The bug has two squiggly antennae.
    5. The bug has two pea-pod shaped wings.
    6. The bug has a spot next to each wing.
    7. The bug has a triangular stinger on the bottom of the body.
    8. The bug has two feelers on each foot — one longer than the other, both coming from the same side of the leg.
    9. The bug has a round mouth, placed between the two eyes.
    10. The bug laid five square eggs to the left of the stinger.
- After everyone is finished... Hold up your bug so others in your group can see. Note some of the similarities and differences. Show the drawing to the entire group.
- **Discussion questions:**
    - Why don't all the bugs look like mine? (Interpretation: everyone has a different interpretation, based on his or her experiences.)
    - What did you think of first when you were told to draw a bug? What did you see in your mind?
    - What could we have done differently so that your drawings and mine would have looked more alike?
    - What would have been the advantages of allowing questions to be asked?
    - How many of you wanted questions to be asked?

Adapted from A Kaleidoscope of Leadership, Minnesota Extension Service

http://www.ag.ohio-state.edu/~bdg/communication.html, Retrieved April 7, 2010

Drawing Bugs



Communication #6
Draw A Bug, p. 1
Building Dynamic Groups Developed by Ohio State University Extension, 2009

Ten Questions to Improve Your Communication Skills

By *Keith Rosen, MCC, The Executive Sales Coach*

The fact is, because most of us were never taught how to communicate in a way that produces desired results, we continue to experience frustration, resistance, conflicts, or breakdowns in our communication. Examine some of the obstacles that may prevent you from reaching certain objectives during the communication process:

- We want to be heard and listened to, but we don't always concentrate on the quality of our message or give the gift of our own attention.
- We want to be understood, yet we often fail to verify that our communication was successful.
- We want acceptance and agreement from others, and we often become consumed with having to be right or to prove our point; we ignore creating a greater outcome together.
- We want some kind of action or response from the other person, but we do not let them know what we really want or how to achieve it.
- We want to understand the message that the other person is communicating to us, yet our ability to listen is tainted by our perceptions of the person speaking and by the outcome we are looking to achieve. So, we often pass judgment on the speaker, evaluating the messenger rather than fully accepting the entire message.

Evolving your communication skills requires taking full responsibility for the outcome of each conversation, responsibility for what you say and for the message that the other person is hearing.

Since we all listen and process information differently, it is crucial to uncover and to become sensitized to the other person's style of communication in order to align it with our own.

To strengthen your communication skills, here are ten questions to ask yourself in order to determine how effectively you communicate:

1. Am I taking full responsibility for the message being heard by the other person? (Remember, it doesn't matter what you say, it only matters what the other person hears.)
2. Did I respect the other person's point of view? Did I have a reaction to what they said that prevented me from listening to their full message?
3. Did the other person feel heard and understood? Did I acknowledge them?
4. If I was asking someone to take a specific action, did I make my request clear?
5. Am I speaking in a way that the other person can understand? Am I communicating in a way that will make the other person want to listen?
6. Am I checking to see if the conversation was successful?
7. Was I communicating openly, without prejudices, expectations, or judgment? Or was I focused on having to be right or on having my point of view be accepted?
8. Did I leave the conversation with some value? Did I allow the other person to contribute?
9. Did I give the person the gift of my listening?
10. If the outcome of the conversation did not meet my expectations, did I learn how to better communicate with that particular person? Did I open up a new and greater possibility that I didn't notice before?

From **http://www.allbusiness.com/sales/selling-techniques-active-listening/4019439-1.html** retrieved April 7, 2010